

Reception of Yeats's "Sailing to Byzantium" Among College Students

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"Sailing to Byzantium" is one of W. B. Yeats's most iconic works, listed among the greatest poems of the 20th century. It spans 32 lines, which are split into four sectioned, yet logically-interconnected ottava rima—stanzas with an "ABABABCC" rhyme pattern and eleven syllables per line. The poem is notorious for being perfectionist, and is said to have taken at least 20 drafts to put together the final form (The London Magazine, 2015). Written circa 1926 and later featured in Yeats's 1928 poetry collection *The Tower*, the first three stanzas of the poem are commonly interpreted as his "definitive statement about the agony of old age" and the "spiritual work required to remain a vital individual" even as the physical corpus is dying (Greatest Poems, n.d.). The final, fourth stanza, is much more opaque about its message: if interpretations do exist, they are often conflicting.

Per Lüdtkke, poetry is traditionally a medium with a great amount of interpretative variability between readers (2014). The root cause of this phenomenon, often referred to by reception theorists as "hermeneutic depth," is especially heightened in the case of "Sailing to Byzantium," where the viscosity of the lines makes the task of interpretation almost insurmountable to an inexperienced reader. Because of that, it is sometimes said that poetry is an acquired pleasure, one which young people lack the introspective capacity to appreciate. The accuracy of this statement can be put to test. This paper will address the following question: How do college students understand such a complex work of poetry as "Sailing to Byzantium"? This paper will apply reception theory to a series of four interviews with college students to argue that while college students are able to make sense of complex texts, that limited understanding hinges on their familiarity with critical analysis and social institutions.

Literature Review

The name “Reception Theory” is often criticized for being vague and unrepresentative of the underlying framework. Broadly, “reception” denotes that data has been collected from a reader at some point of experiencing a particular media text (Whiteley, 2017). Reception theory in critical media studies therefore relates to understanding a text as it is construed and interpreted by the audience (Ott, 2009). The theory was fathered by Wolfgang Iser in Germany throughout the 1960s, where it subsequently became the gold standard for analysis; yet it did not enjoy the same popularity abroad (Holub, 1982). Its greatest edge over classical substantialism is its pragmatic approach to texts: the theory asserts that every text has a finite “horizon of expectations,” regardless of whether the text is active or passive (Thompson, 1993; Tatum, 2014).

The theory did, nonetheless, with time find applications abroad: particularly, in France and the United States. The contemporary American formulation of Reception Theory places emphasis on the meanings encoded into the text, whether the result of decoding varies between readers, and how willing the audience is to accept the true encoded meanings (Ott, 2009). In contrast to the individualistic American approach, French Reception Theory has evolved to define interpretation not as based on individual values and biases, but as reliant on “socio-cultural functioning” (Ventkatesan, 2009). In specifying a cyclical relationship between culture and meaning, French reception theorists assert that poetry has the power to make individuals “relinquish[] the connection to a society that values material goods and profit” (Ventkatesan, 2009). Smith connects the two systems together, stating that the use-value of the poetic text for any given reader is heavily affected by exterior systems—most notably, capitalism

(2024). Finally, Fish adds that the associations made by readers are entirely arbitrary, though partially primed by their expectations of what a text will be (1979). In the end, reception analysis states that reading poetry is heavily influenced by the environment of the reader, and its interpretation does not necessarily follow from its encoded meaning.

“Sailing to Byzantium”

By William Butler Yeats (1928)

I

That is no country for old men. The young
 In one another's arms, birds in the trees,
 —Those dying generations—at their song,
 The salmon-falls, the mackerel-crowded seas,
 Fish, flesh, or fowl, commend all summer long
 Whatever is begotten, born, and dies.
 Caught in that sensual music all neglect
 Monuments of unageing intellect.

II

An aged man is but a paltry thing,
 A tattered coat upon a stick, unless
 Soul clap its hands and sing, and louder sing
 For every tatter in its mortal dress,
 Nor is there singing school but studying
 Monuments of its own magnificence;
 And therefore I have sailed the seas and come
 To the holy city of Byzantium.

III

O sages standing in God's holy fire
 As in the gold mosaic of a wall,
 Come from the holy fire, perne in a gyre,
 And be the singing-masters of my soul.
 Consume my heart away; sick with desire
 And fastened to a dying animal
 It knows not what it is; and gather me
 Into the artifice of eternity.

IV

Once out of nature I shall never take
 My bodily form from any natural thing,
 But such a form as Grecian goldsmiths make
 Of hammered gold and gold enamelling
 To keep a drowsy Emperor awake;
 Or set upon a golden bough to sing
 To lords and ladies of Byzantium
 Of what is past, or passing, or to come.

Methodology

Between Eliot's "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock" and Tennyson's "Ulysses," the paper selected Yeats's "Sailing to Byzantium" as the sole media text for analysis. In a chapter on reception analysis, Jankowski observes that those interviewed had an easier time identifying themes that are personal to them (1991). In accordance with that, the text was chosen for its brevity, perfection, depth, and the calculus of recurring formulaic allusions to the academic setting making the poem easier to interpret.

Following Millard, Rauch, and Sulek, the interviews are conducted in a semi-structured, anonymous format with people at various levels of familiarity with poetry (2009; 2018; 2009). Based on Yavenditti's and Smith's example, providing explanations throughout the interview was strictly prohibited (1974; 2024). With that in mind, Klinger has argued that tangents during the interview process could be conclusive to a better understanding of the texts (1989).

In the end, four one-on-one semi-structured interviews were conducted with college students of the American University of Central Asia. The text was translated into Russian to ease comprehension for non-native speakers, though only two of the interviewees resorted to it.

Results

Even though participants were selected based on their familiarity with poetry, all participants initially rated their knowledge of poetry at 2 out of 5 stars. In spite of that, the inventiveness of the observations made by the participants heavily depended upon their prior exposure to poetry. For that reason, participants will be numbered 1 through 4 based on their level of familiarity with poetry. Although those with a higher ranking were able to extract more

out of the poem, prior exposure to the medium was only a helper, and did not guarantee an independent understanding.

Making Sense of Sailing to Byzantium

Those without a substantial poetic background were unable to fully comprehend the poem. While participants 1 and 2 were able to identify broad themes of the first two stanzas, both struggled with the latter, more abstract stanzas. Participant 1 explains their struggle as due to their upbringing, explaining that it “affects [their] familiarity with poetry and [their] ability to interpret it.” In spite of this struggle, participant 2 asserted that they were able to relate to the narrator: “I also wonder quite often about the significance of our existence and animal existence, and whether everything matters.”

As the interview progressed, though participant 1 found it increasingly difficult to infer the poem, scraping that the third stanza was “very, very spiritual... and very[] personal... to the author.” The overall struggle, as participant 2 put it, stems from a lack of fondness for poetry: “[poetry]’s quite interesting honestly, but it's not something that I [am] largely fascinated about.” In the case of participant 1 and 2, certain prompts regarding their reception of the text went partially or fully unanswered.

In contrast, those who were more familiar with poetry could formulate an independent interpretation of the poem. Participant 4, for instance, gave particular attention to the fish of the first stanza, making the observation that it maintains its autonomy in spite of the narrator’s lamentation, “A very active and living portrayal of fish is created; they swim by themselves and do not yield to others.” Waywards of the second stanza, participant 3 noted that the author’s portrayal of the holy city of Byzantium is more of an ephemeral place, one which does not exist in the real world:

[It is] like paradise, ... where everything is[] perfect. While[] there might not necessarily be bliss,[] there is an absence of pain, and[] I think the author equates that with a sense of detachment from the world, from history, from the flow of time, and passions of the world.

Extrapolating on the third stanza, participant 3 concludes that “Sailing to Byzantium” is meant to serve as a preaching to others, explaining the narrator’s lived experience as entirely human:

The author still implies that there are things to[] yearn after[], even if you’re ready to leave them behind... At the core of his pain, I think there is a desire for happiness.

Even so, all participants struggled with making sense of the final stanza. Participant 2 got hung up on the question of why a “drowsy emperor” needs to be “ke[pt] awake” (Yeats, 1928). Participant 4, however, came out with a critique of the fourth stanza, arguing that it does not allow the narrative to take shape:

I have some difficulty with understanding the ideas put into the fourth stanza. It appears[] the most confusing of all... It is filled with fragments, which at the moment do not click into a single picture. [It’s] supplementing what came before, but they do not allow the narrative to develop... it’s as though either resurrection or unbecoming should take place instead.

Ultimately, every participant could, at least partially, make sense of the poem. Among the four responses, the themes of “death,” “old age,” and “spirituality” appeared consistently. Yet there were also themes that were unique to respondents, such as “seeking,” “romanticism,”

“adaptation,” and “adoration.” The question that stands, then, is what enabled others to make sense of the poem and stalled others.

Institutions as Guardians of Understanding

Only with prior exposure to poetry were participants able to interpret the poem; but it is not prior exposure itself which dictated the interpretation of the poem. Rather, it could be said that the interpretation of poetry in general requires introspective analysis, which social structures enable. As participant 3 points out, it is commonly thought that it is a person’s individual experiences that dictate how a poem is interpreted: “If it rings close to home, if [the readers] feel like they’re [represented] in this character[], [then] they can feel the[] value or [the] quality of the work better.” Yet as French reception points out, the individual experiences stem from “socio-cultural functioning” (Venkatesan, 2009), which indicates that the themes that were picked up most often were in universal, cultural institutions. In a way, then, institutions are guardians of interpretation.

Young people do not have enough contact points to relate to the narrator of “Sailing to Byzantium.” Whether that is due to their own unawareness of ancient history or the old age of the narrator, participants 1 and 2 were unable to latch onto a strand of meaning. In a discussion about the Byzantine empire and its significance, participant 2 conceded that they have not ventured into ancient European history: “I studied history of Central Asia and Mongolia particularly, but I haven’t really gone far to[] this side, which is Europe, I believe.” Participant 3 cited another reason they could not relate to the narrator—the age gap:

As a young person, I think I don’t necessarily relate to the desire that the author[] maybe puts into this poem, because for me, it’s still like the spring of life... Maybe once I gain some life baggage, I’m gonna also think what I’m gonna do after I die.

Even though there were barriers to understanding, some participants were able to relate to the poem through institutional experiences. The third stanza was universally classified as “spiritual” in composition, and provided those who had a former religious background with an inferential lens. For instance, participant 4 says that they can relate to the subjugative hierarchy that gold places upon one:

I would say that I am familiar with at least a few thoughts, which overpower the narrator, especially this comparison of yourself with something small, dying, and blind... I believe, there is a moment with coming under the charm of gold, which the holy hierarchy erects before you... That you do not fit into it, so magnificent and beautiful it seems...

Continuing the extrapolation of the third stanza, participant 3 observes that the author might almost criticize flawed nature of the holy city of Byzantium:

[There's] more of a[n] acceptance of [the] impossibility of maybe achieving a perfect world or[] a perfect life, so you're hoping for there [being] something [that is] welcoming and not as painful as what you've lived...

Even though every single participant has had exposure to religion, only those who have also had exposure to poetry were able to observe it in the poem. That is to say, while institutions guard meaning, familiarity with reading poetry allows readers to approach that.

Why Poetry

It is a mistake to believe that poetry is studied solely for the sake of poetry. Most narratives are comparable to a cabbage plant: just like clasping onto a leaf allows one to peel it back, getting hold of an idea in a text allows one to fully explore it. That meaning needn't have

been purposefully encoded by the author of the text, as Fish proves, and that is what recurrently happened in the decoding of “Sailing to Byzantium” (1979). Similarly to poetry, everyday life features many complex situations with somewhat ambiguous takeaways: from “which side to support in an argument” to “what oversights exist in a proposal.” Being able to comfortably discern and navigate such an environment is generally conclusive, and that is exactly what poetry preaches. Yet at the moment, that skill is far from universal even among students of prestigious universities. Participant 1 stated that it was a “bit hard to interpret... the true intentions[] on [their] end because of [their] lack of familiarity with intensely analyzing poems of these sorts.” Participant 2 added that “[t]he language used [by the poem] is quite understandable, but[] it takes time to sort of puzzle them.” It is true that, as Rauch points out, contemporary media texts are tailored for absent-minded consumption—which does not hold for a medium such as poetry (2018). Critical analysis, fortunately, is a skill that can be acquired with effort. As participant 4 noted in discussing the entirety of the poem:

...there could be this question [raised by the poem] of a person’s adaptation to the conditions set by their life, where [they] are obligated[] to transform their animal nature to fit in. Aside from the [poem’s] theme of death[], there is also the theme of maturation... Not sure if that is a word, but the maturing of the soul, why not?

Which is to say, studying poetry is more than simply admiring art—it also matures the soul. For after all, as Kristeva put it, perhaps poetry does have the capacity to change socio-cultural functioning for the better (Venkatesan, 2009).

Conclusion

The paper applied reception analysis to a series of interviews with college students, arguing that their limited understanding of Yeats's "Sailing to Byzantium" hinges on their familiarity with critical analysis and social institutions. By noting that only participants who have had prior exposure to poetry were able to seek out institutional experiences, the paper demonstrates that critical analysis is foundational to analysis. The paper concludes by stating that poetry should be used to teach critical analysis.

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